

Trench warfare
A re-creation of a Civil War-era trench system, complete with wooden supports (revetments), of the type used at Spotsylvania in 1864. The trenches around the "bloody angle of Spotsylvania" were the scene of savage close-quarters bayonet fighting.

parapets as field fortifications. But there was really no hiding place once battle was joined. If on the defensive, men had to hold firm, firing steadily, in the face of the seemingly unstoppable advance of enemy infantry, and pull back in good order if instructed to do so. On the offensive, they often had to march forward in lines across open ground, despite the relentless depredations of explosive shells and rifle fire. Then would come the order for the final charge with bayonets fixed, through a hail of bullets and grapeshot.

Inevitably, not everyone's nerve held. Some individuals crept away and hid from the mayhem. Mass panics took place in the Union ranks at battles such as Shiloh and Fredericksburg, alongside displays of solid courage and individual heroism. In the heat of battle, even determined soldiers bodged the procedures needed to load and fire their weapon – which involved ripping open the paper cartridge with their teeth, ramming ball and powder down the barrel, and placing a percussion cap in the firing mechanism. Rifles were fired with the ramrod in the barrel or failed to fire because no percussion cap was fitted. Some battles were contested in heavily forested terrain where the fighting soon disintegrated into a savage mêlée.



Whale-oil candles
Candles were an important piece of equipment for soldiers in camp. Candle tins with polished metal surfaces were used to increase illumination and avoid fires while under canvas.

VICTORY OF ATTRITION

Infantry-on-infantry encounters at close range were a terrifying but exhilarating experience. The same could not be said for the trench warfare that predominated in the final stage of the war. Union infantry discovered trenches at the siege of Vicksburg in 1863 but this style of conflict reached its apogee in front of Petersburg in 1864–65. A daily attrition through the explosion of mortar shells and the sniping of enemy sharpshooters replaced the wild slaughter of pitched battle, while soldiers became as adept at the use of pick and spade as of their firearms. By then, precious little was left of the glamour of war that had enthused the volunteers of 1861. For most, the war had become a grim, arduous task that had to be carried through to its conclusion.

Victory came to the Union side in April 1865, but at a price. Some 360,000 Union soldiers died in the conflict, about one in eight of those who served. Those who survived could return home with the satisfaction of having achieved, at their best, an impressive combat performance. When battle-hardened and properly disciplined, Billy Yank exhibited, in the words of one officer, "implicit obedience to orders, undaunted courage, and great endurance". The Confederates may often have fought with more fiery passion, but the Union infantryman ultimately proved to be a stubborn and cool-headed fighter.



Union artillery
Federal ordinance stands at a depot ready for deployment during the siege of Petersburg, 1864–65. Artillery played a major role in the entrenched warfare around the city.